Broad Analytics Association Datathon

2026 Case Competition

Case: Monetizing Trust

Introduction

Pulse is a fast-growing social media platform designed to help users discover and share short-form content centered around hobbies, interests, and emerging communities. Since launching three years ago, Pulse has grown rapidly among Gen Z and young millennial users who value authentic communities and niche content discovery.

The platform has developed strong communities around several interest areas including fitness, gaming, fashion, lifestyle, and creative content. Unlike many major social media platforms, Pulse has built its brand around community trust, transparency, and responsible data practices.

As a result, Pulse has attracted a highly engaged user base that values meaningful online interaction and a platform that respects user privacy.

However, the company now faces a critical business challenge.

While engagement on the platform continues to grow, Pulse has not yet implemented a sustainable monetization strategy.

Platform Scale

Pulse currently has approximately **3.2 million monthly active users globally**.

The datasets provided in this case contain **20,000 users**, representing a **random sample of Pulse's overall user base**. This sample allows teams to analyze user behavior, engagement patterns, monetization potential, and trust-related risks.

Teams should assume that insights derived from the dataset can be **scaled proportionally to the broader Pulse user base** when estimating platform-wide financial impacts.

Business Challenge

Pulse currently holds **$14 million in cash reserves** and operates with a **monthly burn rate of approximately $1.75 million**. At this pace, the company has roughly **8 months of runway remaining**.

Pulse leadership believes the company must extend its runway to **at least 18 months** in order to:

- achieve sustainable revenue growth
- reach profitability milestones
- secure the next round of venture funding

To reach this goal, Pulse leadership estimates the platform must generate approximately **$1 million in monthly revenue starting immediately, before current cash runs out**. The Case Addendum (section 1.5) explains how this target fits with Pulse's eight months of cash.

The challenge is that monetization strategies often introduce tradeoffs between revenue generation and user trust.

Public scrutiny of social media companies has increased due to concerns about:

- targeted advertising practices
- personal data collection
- lack of transparency in how user data is used

Pulse leadership wants to avoid repeating the mistakes made by other social platforms while still building a financially sustainable business.

Internal Strategic Debate

Within Pulse, there is an ongoing debate between two internal teams.

Growth Team Perspective

The Growth Team believes Pulse must begin monetizing the platform aggressively to generate revenue quickly. They argue that targeted advertising and data-driven monetization are proven models used successfully by major social media platforms.

From their perspective, delaying monetization poses a significant risk because the company could run out of capital before achieving scale.

Privacy and Trust Team Perspective

The Privacy and Trust Team believes Pulse's long-term value depends on maintaining strong user trust and protecting user privacy. They warn that aggressive monetization strategies could damage the platform's reputation and lead to user churn.

Their concern is that if highly engaged users leave the platform due to privacy concerns, Pulse could lose the communities that make the platform valuable.

Pulse leadership must determine how to balance **financial sustainability with ethical responsibility**.

Monetization Strategies Under Consideration

Pulse leadership is evaluating several potential monetization strategies. These should be viewed as **starting points for analysis**.

Teams may recommend **one strategy or a combination of up to two strategies**, provided their recommendation is supported by data.

Strategy 1: Targeted Advertising

Pulse would introduce personalized advertisements based on user interests and engagement behavior.

Potential Benefits

- strong revenue potential
- proven monetization model used by major platforms
- scalable as the user base grows

Potential Risks

- increased user concerns about data tracking
- potential trust erosion among privacy-sensitive users
- higher churn risk among highly engaged users

Strategy 2: Aggregated Data Licensing

Pulse could sell anonymized behavioral insights to advertisers, brands, and market research firms.

Potential Benefits

- potentially high enterprise revenue
- does not directly change the user interface

Potential Risks

- ethical concerns around consent and transparency
- reputational damage if users believe their data is being sold

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Strategy 3: Premium Subscription

Pulse could introduce a paid subscription tier offering features such as:

- ad-free experience
- enhanced privacy controls
- premium community features

Potential Benefits

- transparent monetization model
- may increase trust among privacy-conscious users

Potential Risks

- adoption may be limited
- revenue growth may be slower than advertising models

Strategy 4: Brand Insight Partnerships

Pulse could develop analytics dashboards that provide brands with aggregated insights about trends, engagement patterns, and content performance.

Potential Benefits

- less invasive than direct data sales
- creates a business-to-business analytics product

Potential Risks

- slower revenue ramp
- requires investment in analytics infrastructure

The Data

Pulse has provided several datasets containing information about user behavior, engagement patterns, monetization potential, and trust-related risks.

These datasets represent a snapshot of Pulse's current user base and will form the foundation of your analysis.

Teams are encouraged to use **Excel, Tableau, PowerBI, Python, or other analytical tools**.

The four files are also provided pre-joined in one spreadsheet, all_users_combined.xlsx.

Dataset Overview

Dataset 1: user_profiles.csv

This dataset contains demographic and user profile information.

Fields include:

- user_id
- age_group
- region
- account_age_months
- daily_minutes_spent
- sessions_per_week
- content_category_preference
- engagement_score
- influence_score
- privacy_sensitivity_score
- trust_score
- data_sharing_attitude

Dataset 2: engagement_behavior.csv

This dataset captures how users interact with content and communities.

Fields include:

- user_id
- posts_per_week
- likes_per_week
- shares_per_week
- comments_per_week
- content_views_per_day
- creator_interaction_score
- community_engagement_score

Dataset 3: monetization_potential.csv

This dataset estimates revenue potential for different monetization strategies.

Fields include:

- user_id
- predicted_ad_revenue_per_month
- subscription_willingness_score
- max_subscription_price
- data_value_score
- brand_insight_value_score

Dataset 4: risk_and_churn_metrics.csv

This dataset captures user risk indicators and potential reactions to monetization strategies.

Fields include:

- user_id
- baseline_churn_probability
- ad_targeting_churn_risk
- data_sale_churn_risk
- subscription_adoption_probability
- trust_loss_if_data_sold
- trust_loss_if_ads

Your Mission

Pulse leadership must determine how to monetize the platform while maintaining user trust and long-term sustainability.

Using the datasets provided, your team will analyze user behavior, engagement patterns, monetization potential, and trust-related risks in order to develop a data-driven recommendation.

Teams may recommend **one monetization strategy or a combination of up to two strategies**.

All recommendations must be supported by **quantitative analysis and ethical reasoning**.

Key Questions

1. User Value and Risk Segmentation

Using the provided data, identify the most valuable user segments on the platform.

Consider:

- engagement levels
- influence within the platform
- monetization potential
- privacy sensitivity and trust indicators

Which user groups drive the most value for Pulse, and which segments present the greatest churn or ethical risk?

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2. Monetization Strategy Analysis

Evaluate the potential impact of Pulse's monetization strategies.

Estimate:

- expected revenue generation
- potential user adoption
- risk of user churn or trust loss

Which strategy, or combination of strategies, provides the best balance between revenue generation and maintaining trust?

3. Strategic Recommendation

Based on your analysis, recommend a monetization strategy for Pulse leadership.

Explain:

- why the strategy is financially viable
- how it helps extend Pulse's runway to 18 months
- how the strategy addresses ethical concerns around user data and privacy

Support your recommendation with **clear data analysis and visualizations**.

A note on user loss: Some of these strategies will cause users to leave Pulse. If you can put a number on that, great. If you can't, it is completely fine to reason in plain words about who might leave and why. Clear thinking about user loss earns credit either way.